

From Online Rants to Illegal Acts: The Role of Dark Tetrad in Illegal Political Participation

Jinwan Kim¹ and Yonghwan Kim²

¹*College of Journalism & Communications, University of Florida*

²*Department of Media & Communication, Dongguk University*

Introduction

Political extremism and illegal political behavior have become increasingly visible across the globe, posing significant challenges to public safety and democratic institutions. Recent years have witnessed a series of high-profile incidents, including violent court intrusions by supporters of a former president in South Korea, anti-immigration riots in the Netherlands, and the assassination or politically motivated attacks targeting public figures in the United States. Prior research further suggests that support for political violence has increased across partisan lines in the United States (Kalmoe & Mason, 2022). These are further corroborated by recent reports. The Princeton Bridging Divides Initiative's 2024 report documents an increase in vigilante violence, particularly in the United States (Bridging Divides Initiative, 2025), while the International Crisis Group's CrisisWatch report identifies multiple regions experiencing heightened political conflict and declining political stability (International Crisis Group, 2024). Collectively, these cases and findings suggest a broader escalation of politically motivated violence involving both state-related and non-state actors, underscoring the urgency of understanding the mechanisms driving contemporary political conflict.

Despite growing attention to political participation and extremism, research on illegal political behavior remains limited and fragmented. Much of the existing literature has focused on legally permissible forms of political participation, particularly those that are

negative or confrontational in nature, such as online incivility or contentious political expression. While these studies provide important insights into antagonistic forms of engagement, they stop short of addressing behaviors that cross legal boundaries. Moreover, the relatively few studies that do examine illegal political participation have largely focused on youth populations (Dahl & Stattin, 2016; Dahl & Van Zalk, 2014; Gavray et al., 2012). As a result, we lack a comprehensive understanding of how illegal political behavior emerges among the broader population, particularly in contemporary digital environments.

Emerging evidence suggests that the digital environment plays a central role in shaping extreme political behaviors. Social media platforms not only facilitate rapid information dissemination but also foster ideologically homogeneous networks and amplify affective polarization, thereby increasing the likelihood of hostile political interactions (Del Vicario et al., 2016; Geschke et al., 2019; Pariser, 2011). Within these environments, political homophily reinforces echo chambers, reduces exposure to cross-cutting perspectives, and contributes to the normalization of extreme viewpoints (Cheng et al., 2024; De Francisci Morales et al., 2021). Moreover, online spaces often enable anonymity and reduced social accountability, creating conditions in which uncivil and norm-violating behaviors become more prevalent (Santana, 2014). Together, these dynamics suggest that online interactions may serve as a pathway through which political hostility escalates into more extreme forms of engagement.

A growing body of research on online incivility further indicates that exposure to uncivil or hateful content is widespread and is associated with non-institutional political participation (Min et al., 2025). However, this literature has largely focused on passive exposure—simply witnessing uncivil content—rather than active engagement and its behavioral consequences. In particular, little is known about how negative but legally permissible forms of online political engagement may escalate into illegal political

participation. Prior research has tended to treat normative and non-normative political behaviors as distinct categories, leaving the transition between them insufficiently theorized and empirically tested.

Building on this gap, this study conceptualizes negative online political engagement as a key mediating mechanism. Such engagement includes behaviors that remain within legal boundaries. Although legally permissible, these behaviors may normalize hostility and lower psychological thresholds for escalation, thereby facilitating transitions toward unlawful political participation.

Individual personality traits may further shape this process. In particular, the socially aversive dispositions captured by the Dark Tetrad—Machiavellianism, narcissism, psychopathy, and sadism—have been consistently linked to aggression and antisocial behavior (Frischlich et al., 2021; Jonason et al., 2017; Paulhus & Williams, 2002). Individuals high in these traits may be more likely to translate negative online engagement into illegal political action, suggesting that the Dark Tetrad moderates the relationship between online hostility and unlawful participation.

Therefore, this study proposes a multi-level framework in which political homophily contributes to illegal political participation indirectly through negative online political engagement, while Dark Tetrad traits moderate the link between online hostility and unlawful political behavior. In doing so, the study makes three contributions: (1) it advances understanding of how digital social networks shape conditions under which individuals transgress the normative boundaries of political participation, (2) it identifies the mechanism through which legally permissible but negative online political engagement escalates into illegal political action, and (3) it demonstrates how socially aversive personality traits moderate this transition.

Political homophily on social media

Social media platforms have fundamentally transformed how individuals access and engage with political information by enabling highly personalized information environments.

Platforms such as YouTube and Facebook curate content based on both explicit user choices (e.g., subscriptions and settings) and implicit behavioral signals derived from engagement patterns. Through these mechanisms, users are increasingly embedded in algorithmically and behaviorally filtered information ecosystems that prioritize attitude-consistent content and like-minded sources (Dylko & McCluskey, 2012).

This development is consistent with the theory of selective exposure, which posits that individuals preferentially seek out information that aligns with their preexisting beliefs while avoiding incongruent viewpoints (Iyengar & Hahn, 2009). Online communication environments tend to reinforce this tendency by repeatedly exposing users to ideologically congruent content, thereby reducing exposure to opposing perspectives and limiting attitudinal ambivalence (Wojcieszak & Mutz, 2009). Over time, such exposure patterns may contribute to increased attitudinal polarization and heightened political engagement within ideologically homogeneous networks (Eveland & Hively, 2009).

Taken together, the affordances of digital platforms amplify selective exposure processes by enabling users to actively curate their networks and by algorithmically reinforcing content congruence. Features such as personalized feeds, recommendation systems, and social filtering tools increase user control over information environments while simultaneously narrowing the diversity of political content encountered online (Dylko & McCluskey, 2012). As a result, individuals are more likely to operate within ideologically homogeneous environments that reinforce existing beliefs and reduce cross-cutting political exposure.

Within such environments, political homophily emerges as a defining characteristic of online networks. Politically homophilous networks can be described as dense clusters of

within-group ties that are relatively insulated from dissenting viewpoints, fostering both political cohesion and intergroup discord (Boutyline & Willer, 2017). The expansion of digital media has further enabled individuals to form self-organized networks of like-minded users, reinforcing shared identities and facilitating political mobilization (Bennett & Segerberg, 2023; Flanagin et al., 2006). Empirical evidence supports the prevalence of political homophily in online contexts. For example, a study of political activity on YouTube in South Korea found minimal overlap between left- and right-leaning users, with interactions strongly clustered within ideologically aligned channels (Tran et al., 2022). These findings indicate that users tend to engage primarily with others who share similar political views, reinforcing cohesive but polarized communities.

Importantly, such homophilous environments contribute to broader psychological and behavioral consequences. Limited exposure to diverse viewpoints fosters echo chambers and intensifies polarization, which in turn increases political anger and hostility toward opposing groups (Gillani et al., 2018; Iyengar et al., 2019; Vaccari et al., 2016). Political anger plays a crucial role in motivating political action, as individuals become more likely to act against groups that they perceive as threatening or blameworthy (Holmes, 2004). This emotional dynamic can further reinforce selective exposure, strengthen existing beliefs, and increase the likelihood of uncivil communication and even aggressive or violent behavior (Gervais, 2017; Petersen & Zukerman, 2010; Suhay & Erisen, 2018).

In conclusion, political homophily on social media reflects the tendency for individuals to engage with like-minded others within algorithmically and socially curated environments. Although digital platforms have the potential to expose users to diverse perspectives, they often promote homogeneous information ecosystems that reinforce in-group identities, intensify polarization, and heighten political hostility (Cheng et al., 2024).

These dynamics suggest that political homophily may serve as a critical antecedent to more negative forms of political engagement in online settings.

Negative online political engagement and illegal political participation

Negative forms of political expression in online environments have become increasingly prevalent in contemporary digital communication. Interactions within politically homophilous networks are positively associated with heightened emotional responses, particularly political anger (Cheng et al., 2024). While political anger can motivate political participation, it also fosters uncivil and hostile forms of communication, deepens partisan divides, and, in some cases, contributes to support for or engagement in political violence (Claassen, 2016; Hasell & Weeks, 2016; Huber et al., 2015).

Online environments are especially conducive to such negative expressions due to their structural and psychological characteristics. The relative anonymity of social media reduces social accountability and facilitates the use of uncivil language, particularly during periods of heightened political conflict (Min et al., 2025). Incivility, broadly defined as communication that violates norms of respectful discourse (Kenski et al., 2020; Papacharissi, 2004), often manifests in forms such as offensive speech, derogatory comments, and hate speech (Muddiman, 2017). Importantly, these behaviors typically remain within legal boundaries, making them more accessible and socially tolerated forms of political expression.

Compared to offline participation, online political engagement requires lower levels of effort, risk, and commitment, making it more accessible and easier to engage in (Beer, 2009), enabling individuals to express negative opinions or hostility with minimal constraints. This low-cost and low-threshold nature of online participation makes it more likely that individuals engage in antagonistic behaviors without extensive deliberation. As a result, online environments may function as spaces where individuals gradually normalize hostility and become desensitized to norm-violating behavior.

A growing body of research suggests that online political activity does not remain confined to the digital sphere but often translates into offline political participation. Synthesizing findings across multiple studies, Angyal and Fellner (2020) demonstrate that engagement in online political activities is positively associated with offline political involvement, supporting the mobilization hypothesis. This relationship implies that behaviors developed in online contexts may extend into real-world political action.

Building on this perspective, negative but legally permissible forms of online political engagement may serve as a critical intermediary mechanism linking online social environments to illegal political participation. Repeated engagement in uncivil or hostile interactions may lower psychological barriers to more extreme actions, thereby increasing the likelihood that individuals move from normative forms of participation to non-normative or unlawful behaviors.

Although prior research has examined illegal political participation, it has largely focused on adolescent populations. These studies suggest that illegal participation often coexists with conventional political engagement and is shaped by factors such as peer influence, perceived efficacy, and attitudes toward authority (Dahl & Stattin, 2016; Dahl & Van Zalk, 2014; Gavray et al., 2012). However, such work provides limited insight into how these behaviors emerge among the broader population, particularly within digitally mediated environments.

Taken together, this study conceptualizes negative online political engagement as a key mediating mechanism through which political homophily may indirectly contribute to illegal political participation. By focusing on online forms of engagement—where political expression is more immediate, less constrained, and more easily normalized, this approach highlights how legally permissible behaviors can accumulate and escalate into more

consequential and potentially unlawful political actions. Therefore, the following hypotheses are posed:

H1: Political homophily on social media will positively relate to negative online political engagement.

H2: Negative online political engagement will positively relate to illegal political participation.

H3: Negative online political engagement will mediate the relationship between political homophily on social media and illegal political participation.

Dark Tetrad

Personality has long been recognized as a key determinant of political behavior, shaping how individuals perceive, interpret, and respond to political environments (Gallego & Oberski, 2012). Prior research has predominantly focused on the Big Five personality traits, demonstrating that individual differences in traits such as openness and extraversion are associated with variations in political participation (Gallego & Oberski, 2012; Weinschenk, 2017). However, this line of research has largely overlooked the role of socially aversive personality traits, particularly in explaining non-normative or illegal forms of political behavior (Chen et al., 2021).

To address this gap, the present study focuses on the Dark Tetrad, a set of socially malevolent personality traits comprising Machiavellianism, narcissism, psychopathy, and sadism. These traits are characterized by antagonism, callousness, and self-serving tendencies, and are consistently linked to antisocial and aggressive behavior (Jones & Figueredo, 2013; Marcus et al., 2018; Paulhus, 2014). The Dark Tetrad extends the earlier Dark Triad framework—Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy (Paulhus & Williams, 2002)—by incorporating everyday sadism, defined as deriving pleasure from harming others or engaging in cruelty for its own sake (Buckels et al., 2013).

Each component of the Dark Tetrad is associated with distinct patterns of political behavior. Machiavellianism, characterized by strategic manipulation and a cynical worldview, has been linked to lower ideological commitment and more instrumental forms of political engagement (Christie & Geis, 2013; Rogoza et al., 2022). In contrast, narcissism is associated with heightened political participation driven by self-enhancement motives, as individuals seek attention and status through visible forms of engagement (Blais & Pruyers, 2017; Pruyers et al., 2019). Psychopathy, marked by impulsivity, low empathy, and risk-taking tendencies, has been consistently associated with non-normative and destabilizing forms of political action, including illegal protest (Besta et al., 2021). Sadism, reflecting enjoyment derived from others' suffering, is likewise theorized to increase the likelihood of hostile or harmful political behavior. Empirical research largely supports these distinctions, with evidence indicating that psychopathy and narcissism are more reliably associated with non-normative political participation—particularly in polarized contexts—whereas Machiavellianism shows more mixed and context-dependent associations (Besta et al., 2021; Rogoza et al., 2022).

Building on this perspective, personality traits may not only exert direct effects on political participation but also interact with contextual factors to shape behavioral outcomes (Mondak et al., 2010). In particular, the Dark Tetrad may strengthen the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation. Individuals high in these traits are more likely to interpret and enact hostile online interactions in ways that facilitate escalation into unlawful behavior. Thus, the Dark Tetrad is conceptualized as a key moderating factor that amplifies the transition from legally permissible but negative political engagement to illegal political action. Therefore, the following hypothesis is posed:

H4: Dark Tetrad will moderate the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation.

Data

A two-wave national online panel survey was conducted by Hankook Research, a professional research firm, in March 2024. A stratified quota sampling technique was employed to obtain a sample representative of the national population, based on Korean census benchmarks for key demographic characteristics, including age, gender, education, and household income. The final sample consisted of 908 Korean adults aged 18 years or older.

Measures

Political homophily on social media (W1)

Respondents were asked to indicate the extent to which they agreed with the following statements while thinking about their usual use of social media: “I tend to consume news or content that aligns with my views when I am online or on social media,” “I mostly communicate with people similar to myself and associate with those who share similar opinions when I am online or on social media,” and “I tend to avoid content that does not align with my opinions, especially news and political discussions, when I am online or on social media.” Responses were measured on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree ($M = 3.03$, $SD = 0.77$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = .67$, McDonald’s $\omega = 0.69$).

Negative political online engagement (W1)

Respondents were asked how frequently they had engaged in political activities during the past six months. Specifically, they were asked to indicate how often they had performed the following actions: “posting negative comments about politicians,” “posting negative comments about a particular political party,” “posting satirical images or videos about political parties or politicians,” and “posting negative remarks about people who hold

different political views.” Responses were measured on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = never to 5 = very often ($M = 1.67$, $SD = 0.88$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = .94$, McDonald’s $\omega = 0.95$).

Dark tetrad (W1)

Based on previous studies (Katz et al., 2022; Kwon et al., 2023), respondents were asked to indicate the extent to which they agreed with statements describing their typical personality tendencies. Machiavellianism was measured with four items: “I tend to keep people who can be useful to me close,” “I tend to avoid conflicts with people who help me,” “I tend to plan ahead to avoid unexpected situations,” and “I tend to maintain good relationships with others through polite and courteous behavior” ($M = 4.01$, $SD = 0.48$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.63$, McDonald’s $\omega = 0.65$). Narcissism was measured with five items: “I naturally take on a leadership role in groups I belong to,” “I am good at persuading others,” “People around me tend to say that I am special,” “I believe I have superior abilities compared to others,” and “I am confident that I will succeed in certain areas” ($M = 3.12$, $SD = 0.67$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.82$, McDonald’s $\omega = 0.86$). Psychopathy was measured with six items: “I enjoy showing off,” “People often say that I am difficult to deal with,” “I tend to challenge authority,” “I tend to argue more frequently than my peers,” “Those who make me angry will regret it,” and “I know how to hurt others with my words” ($M = 2.68$, $SD = 0.60$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.69$, McDonald’s $\omega = 0.77$). Sadism was measured with three items: “I enjoy violent movies or video games,” “I have found it amusing when others fail,” and “I enjoy watching combat sports” ($M = 2.08$, $SD = 0.81$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.68$, McDonald’s $\omega = 0.70$). All responses were measured on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree.

Illegal political participation (W2)

Respondents were asked how frequently they had engaged in political activities during the past six months. Specifically, they were asked to indicate how often they had performed the

following actions: “I violated the law for political purposes,” “I broke the law due to political reasons,” “I participated in an illegal protest,” and “I occupied a road without permission for protest purposes.” Although all responses were initially measured on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree, the distribution of responses was highly skewed positively. Therefore, the items were recoded into dichotomous indicators, such that responses of 4 (“agree”) and 5 (“strongly agree”) were coded as 1, and all other responses were coded as 0. The recoded items were then summed to create an index ranging from 0 to 4, with higher values indicating greater engagement in illegal political participation ($M = 0.61$, $SD = 1.28$, Cronbach’s $\alpha = .93$, McDonald’s $\omega = 0.96$).

Control Variables

Several control variables were included in the analysis. First, key demographic characteristics were controlled, including age (Median = 4 [40–49]), gender (51% male), household income (Median = 5 [~~₩~~4,000,000–~~₩~~4,990,000], range = 1 “~~₩~~0–~~₩~~2,000,000” to 9 “~~₩~~10,000,000 or more”), and education (Median = 4 [college], range = 1 “less than middle school” to 4 “graduate school”).

Second, political variables identified in prior research as important predictors of political behavior were controlled, including political interest (Mungall et al., 2025), political knowledge (Gil de Zúñiga & Goyanes, 2023), and political ideology (Cloudy et al., 2024; Mungall et al., 2025).

In addition, conspiracy belief was included as a control variable. Prior research suggests that embracing a conspiratorial worldview reduces individuals’ willingness to engage in conventional political participation while increasing their propensity for unconventional or illegal forms of political behavior (Imhoff et al., 2021). Moreover, conspiracy beliefs can foster alternative social realities characterized by distrust and shifting norms, which may further encourage non-normative behavior (Pummerer, 2022).

To account for prior behavioral tendencies, both legal and illegal political participation at Wave 1 were controlled. Illegal political participation should not be treated as isolated behavior but rather as closely intertwined with prior legal and political engagement (Inguanzo et al., 2022). Furthermore, exposure to and participation in online political discourse, including uncivil interactions have been shown to predict individuals' own uncivil behavior (Frischlich et al., 2021). Failing to account for prior participation may therefore lead to overestimation or misattribution of the effects of key explanatory variables.

Finally, traditional media use was included as a control variable

Analysis

The hypotheses were tested using the PROCESS macro (v3.3) for SPSS developed by Hayes (2017), specifically Models 4 and 14. In addition to the control variables described above, the Dark Tetrad traits were included as covariates when testing H1–H3. Furthermore, when examining each Dark Tetrad trait individually, the remaining three traits were included as control variables to provide more conservative and unbiased estimates of the effects. Bias-corrected bootstrap confidence intervals were estimated using 5,000 bootstrap samples, and all confidence intervals were set at the 95% level.

Results

We expected that political homophily would be related to negative online political engagement (H1) and that negative online political engagement would, in turn, be related to illegal political participation (H2). The results show that political homophily is positively associated with negative online political engagement ($B = 0.0633$, $SE = 0.0306$, $p = .0391$). In addition, negative online political engagement is positively associated with illegal political participation ($B = 0.3695$, $SE = 0.0532$, $p < .001$). Therefore, both H1 and H2 are supported.

We further expected that negative online political engagement would mediate the relationship between political homophily and illegal political participation (H3). The results

indicate that political homophily is indirectly associated with illegal political participation through negative online political engagement (indirect effect = 0.0234, $SE = 0.0117$, 95% CI [0.0016, 0.0467]). Because the confidence interval does not include zero, the indirect effect is statistically significant, supporting H3.

We further examined whether each Dark Tetrad trait moderates the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation. The results show that the interaction between negative online political engagement and Machiavellianism is statistically significant ($B = -0.2722$, $SE = 0.0795$, $p = .0006$), indicating that the positive association between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation becomes weaker as levels of Machiavellianism increase. A Johnson–Neyman analysis further indicated that this conditional effect was statistically significant only at lower levels of Machiavellianism and became non-significant beyond a certain threshold, suggesting a boundary condition for the effect.

We next examined whether narcissism and psychopathy moderate the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation. The interaction effects were not statistically significant for either narcissism ($B = -0.0238$, $SE = 0.0611$, $p = .6963$) or psychopathy ($B = -0.0132$, $SE = 0.0708$, $p = .8518$), suggesting that neither trait conditions this relationship.

Finally, we examined whether sadism moderates the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation. The interaction between negative online political engagement and sadism was statistically significant ($B = 0.0971$, $SE = 0.0473$, $p = .0405$), indicating that the positive association between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation becomes stronger as levels of sadism increase. A Johnson–Neyman analysis revealed that the conditional effect remained statistically

significant across the entire observed range of sadism, indicating a robust and consistently positive association.

Discussion

This study investigated how political homophily in social media environments contributes to illegal political participation, focusing on the mediating role of negative online political engagement and the moderating role of Dark Tetrad traits. The findings provide several important theoretical and empirical contributions.

First, this study identifies a clear mechanism linking political homophily to illegal political participation. Contemporary media environments increasingly frame politics through antagonistic and conflict-driven narratives, in which disagreement and intergroup tension are emphasized over substantive deliberation (McLaughlin et al., 2026). Such portrayals do not merely reflect political reality but actively construct a mediated environment in which political conflict becomes more salient, emotionally charged, and personally relevant. Building on this perspective, the present findings demonstrate that political homophily in social media increases negative online political engagement, which in turn promotes illegal political participation. Rather than merely reinforcing pre-existing attitudes, ideologically homogeneous environments appear to foster emotionally intensified forms of engagement by continuously exposing individuals to ingroup-confirming cues and outgroup-referential narratives. Such repeated exposure may contribute to heightened perceptions of ideological opposition and the normalization of hostile communicative practices, including flaming, derogatory commenting, and affectively charged interaction patterns.

Importantly, negative online political engagement fully mediated the relationship between political homophily and illegal political participation. This indicates that the influence of homophily operates primarily through affective and behavioral pathways rather than through a direct behavioral link. In line with the Cognitive-Affective Processing System

framework (Mischel & Shoda, 1995), behavior is understood as emerging from the interaction between situational cues, cognitive interpretations, and affective responses rather than as a direct outcome of environmental exposure. From this perspective, ideologically homogeneous networks may shape emotional and interactional responses by repeatedly exposing individuals to ingroup–outgroup cues. These affective responses are reflected in negative online political engagement, which serves as a proximal expression of underlying cognitive-affective processes. Such engagement may in turn facilitate the translation of online hostility into offline contexts, increasing the likelihood of illegal political participation.

Second, this study contributes to the Dark Tetrad literature by demonstrating that these personality traits function as boundary conditions that shape the strength—but not the existence—of the behavioral pathway from negative online political engagement to illegal political participation. Although the overall mediated mechanism remained stable, its magnitude varied depending on specific personality dispositions.

Machiavellianism significantly moderates the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation, attenuating the strength of this association at higher levels of Machiavellianism. As prior research suggests, Machiavellian individuals are characterized by calculated decision-making, instrumental rationality, and strategic self-monitoring (Abell & Brewer, 2014; Christie & Geis, 1970). Rather than acting on immediate affective impulses generated in online environments, they are more likely to evaluate potential risks and long-term consequences. The Johnson–Neyman analysis further supports this interpretation by showing that the effect of negative online engagement becomes non-significant beyond a certain level of Machiavellianism. This suggests that Machiavellianism may function as a behavioral constraint, reducing the likelihood that online hostility escalates into offline illegal actions at higher levels of Machiavellianism. Thus,

Machiavellianism functions not as an amplifying antisocial trait but as a conditional inhibitory factor in behavioral escalation within politically consequential contexts

In contrast, sadism significantly moderates the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation, strengthening this association. This finding suggests that sadism strengthens the positive association between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation. Sadism reflects an intrinsic tendency to derive pleasure from others' suffering and from antagonistic interactions. In online political contexts, negative engagement itself may be reinforced, as hostile expression and conflictual exchanges provide emotional or hedonic reward. Unlike Machiavellianism, the Johnson–Neyman results indicate that this effect remains significant across the entire range of sadism, suggesting a relatively consistent strengthening pattern rather than a threshold-based discontinuity. In other words, sadism consistently strengthens the likelihood that online hostility translates into illegal behavior. This aligns with prior research linking sadistic traits to online aggression and trolling (Buckels et al., 2014) and extends these findings by suggesting their possible relevance for political escalation. However, the non-significant moderated mediation index suggests that, although the association is consistently positive and stronger at higher levels, the overall pattern does not constitute a statistically distinct moderated mediation process.

By contrast, narcissism and psychopathy did not significantly moderate the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation, nor did they produce significant moderated mediation effects. These null findings are theoretically meaningful. Narcissism is primarily driven by self-enhancement and the pursuit of recognition (Buffardi & Campbell, 2008; McCain & Campbell, 2018). Its behavioral expression is oriented toward visibility and admiration rather than risk-taking political escalation. Consequently, while narcissistic individuals may engage in online self-

presentation, this does not appear to significantly moderate the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation. Similarly, psychopathy is characterized by impulsivity, emotional coldness, and reduced empathy (Hare, 1999), and is associated with short-term stimulation-seeking behaviors such as trolling and provocative online communication (Buckels et al., 2014; Garcia & Sikström, 2014; Paulhus et al., 2021). However, these behaviors are often contextually diffuse and lack the cognitive framing or goal continuity required for ideologically driven illegal political action. Thus, psychopathy may facilitate antisocial expression online but does not necessarily extend into structured political escalation.

Taken together, these findings suggest that the pathway appears to be structurally generalizable but psychologically heterogeneous. While most individuals may follow a similar trajectory from homophilous exposure to negative online engagement and subsequently to offline behavior, the relationship between negative online political engagement and illegal political participation varies depending on individual personality traits. More specifically, Machiavellianism operates as a conditional inhibitory mechanism that limits behavioral escalation through cost–benefit reasoning, whereas sadism functions as a stable amplifying mechanism that reinforces hostile engagement across contexts. Narcissism and psychopathy, in contrast, appear largely decoupled from politically consequential escalation processes, highlighting that not all antisocial traits translate into politically meaningful offline behavior.

Finally, this study has broader implications for understanding contemporary political participation in digitally mediated environments. As political interaction increasingly occurs within ideologically homogeneous online networks, the boundary between online expression and offline action becomes more permeable. The findings suggest that exposure to homophilous environments and engagement in negative online discourse may normalize non-

institutional and illegal forms of political participation, including unlawful protest, harassment, and politically motivated aggression. Importantly, these results underscore that digital political environments do not operate independently of individual psychological differences. Instead, political outcomes emerge from the interaction between structural exposure (homophily), behavioral processes (online engagement), and dispositional traits (Dark Tetrad). These findings highlight the importance of considering both network structures and individual differences when examining political behavior in digital environments.

This study has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings. First, the measurement of online political engagement and illegal political participation relies on self-reported survey data. Although anonymity and survey design can reduce social desirability bias, sensitive behaviors such as illegal political actions are still susceptible to underreporting, particularly given their low base rate and skewed distribution. Future research could benefit from incorporating behavioral trace data or other objective indicators to complement self-reports and improve measurement robustness.

Second, while this study focuses on Dark Tetrad traits as key moderators, personality-based explanations of political behavior are inherently multi-dimensional. Individuals are unlikely to be adequately characterized by a single trait in isolation, and these traits often co-occur to varying degrees within the same person. In other words, most individuals possess a combination of these dispositions, and it is their joint configuration rather than any single trait that more accurately reflects underlying personality structure. Accordingly, antisocial or norm-violating political behavior is unlikely to be fully explained by one dominant trait alone. Future research should therefore move beyond isolated trait-based explanations and adopt more integrative approaches that capture the co-activation and interaction of multiple personality dimensions within individuals.

Third, the sample is drawn from a single national context, which may limit the generalizability of the findings. Political communication norms, levels of polarization, and tolerance for non-institutional political behavior vary across societies. Accordingly, future cross-national research is needed to test the external validity of the proposed model.

Finally, several key variables in this study, including political homophily on social media and Machiavellianism, showed reliability coefficients below 0.70 for both Cronbach's alpha and McDonald's omega. Although Cronbach's alpha values above 0.60 are generally considered acceptable (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994; Pallant, 2001) these results suggest relatively limited internal consistency. Political homophily is inherently a relational and context-dependent construct, reflecting patterns of social connection and interaction rather than a stable individual attribute (McPherson et al., 2001). In digital environments, such patterns coexist with heterogeneous information exposure and algorithmically structured content flows, which may complicate the operationalization of a clearly bounded measurement construct (Guess, 2021). As a result, survey-based measures of political homophily may only partially capture the dynamic and networked nature of online political environments. A similar concern applies to Machiavellianism, which is a multidimensional personality construct encompassing strategic manipulation, cynicism, and instrumental rationality (Christie & Geis, 1970). These facets may not co-vary uniformly across items, potentially contributing to reduced internal consistency and attenuated reliability estimates. Furthermore, Dark Triad traits are known to be particularly susceptible to measurement challenges in self-report surveys due to social desirability bias and response distortion (Abell & Brewer, 2014; Paulhus et al., 2021). Taken together, these considerations suggest that both political homophily and Machiavellianism involve a degree of conceptual and measurement complexity that should be taken into account when interpreting the observed effects. Nonetheless, the use of established scales and theoretically grounded constructs provides

sufficient basis for the analysis, while also highlighting the need for further refinement of measurement strategies in future research.

Despite these limitations, the present findings provide meaningful insights into how network structures, behavioral engagement, and personality traits jointly shape illegal political participation in digital environments.

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